The Shattered Obelisk

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Characters

Who	Character	Race	Str	Int	Wis	Dex	Con	Cha	AC	HP
Jim	Lilar Hearthsong	Human Cleric	12 (+1)	10	16 (+3)	10	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	12+2	10
NPC	Amara Solbright	Human Cleric	12 (+1)	10	16 (+3)	10	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	12+2	11
Rose	Aeliana Moonglade	Elf Ranger	10	16 (+3)	15 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	10	14	12
Wayne	Thorgrim Stoneheart	Dwarf Fighter	16 (+3)	10	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	16	10	18+2	13
Kristin	Seraphina Duskwhispe	H-Elf Rogue	8 (-1)	14 (+2)	10	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	11	9
Neala	Kaelin Brightspark	Halfling Bard	8	12 (+1)	10	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	16 (+3)	11	9
NPC	Varrack Ironflame	Elf Sorcerer	10	16 (+3)	10	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)	8	8

Who	Character	Abilities	Spells
Jim	Lilar Hearthsong	Medicine (+2) Wisdom Intimidation (+2) Charisma	Healing Word (1d4+1) Bless up to 3 with 1d4 to hit/save Guiding Bolt 4d6 @120 + advantage
NPC	Amara Solbright	Religion (+2) Intelligence Insight (+2) Wisdom	Bless up to 3 with 1d4 to hit/save Healing Word (1d4+1) Detect Evil & Good
Rose	Aeliana Moonglade	Survival (+2) Wisdom Perception (+2) Wisdom	Speak with Animals Animal Friendship Fog Cloud 20 ft
Wayne	Thorgrim Stoneheart	Familiarity with weapons Second Wind (1d10) Athletics (+2) Strength Intimidation (+2) Charisma	
Kristin	Seraphina Duskwhisper	Sneak Attack (1d6) Thieves Cant Deception (+2) Charisma Sleight of Hand (+2) Dex	
Neala	Kaelin Brightspark	Performance (+2) Charisma Persuasion (+2) Charisma	Bardic Inspiration Nx1d6 to hit/save Cure Wounds (1d8) HP Faerie Fire illuminating colored aura
NPC	Varrack Ironflame	Investigation (+2) Intelligence Stealth (+2) Dexterity	Magic Missile (3x1d4+1) Mage Armor (1xAC13) for 8 hrs Burning Hands (3d6) within 30 ft Detect Magic within 30 ft

Introduction

A remote frontier town called Driftmoor is nestled near the jagged cliffs of the Obelisk Reach. The region is known for its mysterious ancient ruins and strange phenomena tied to an ancient, shattered obelisk that looms over the land.

The town of Driftmoor has recently been plagued by bizarre events—shadows that move of their own accord, livestock disappearing, and strange symbols appearing in fields overnight. A local scholar, Elyssa Moonglow, believes these disturbances are tied to the shattered obelisk that looms over the cliffs, a relic of a long-forgotten civilization.

The Region Around Driftmoor

1. Driftmoor Town

Perched on a rocky coast where the Greywater River flows into the Azure Sea. Driftmoor is nestled between jagged cliffs and windswept plains, giving it an isolated but picturesque setting. It has a population of ~500; mostly humans, halflings, and a few dwarves and elves.

Key Features:

- **The Harbor District**: A small harbor sheltered by rocky outcroppings. Wooden piers and fishing boats dominate the scene, with ramshackle homes belonging to the fisherfolk. The waters are teeming with fish, but the occasional shadowy form beneath the surface unnerves the locals.
- **The Village Center**: The heart of Driftmoor, where modest stone and timber buildings house shops, a tavern (The Broken Lantern), and the mayor's hall.
- **Farms and Fields**: A mile upriver are scattered farms growing hardy grains, root vegetables, and some grazing livestock. Farmers often transport their goods downstream to the harbor by raft.

2. The Obelisk Reach

A jagged expanse of cliffs and rocky plateaus north of Driftmoor, named for the shattered obelisk that looms over the landscape. The terrain is treacherous, with narrow paths, hidden caves, and eerie rock formations. The obelisk's ruins are the source of local legends and the Shadowbeasts plaguing the area. Strange symbols carved into the cliffs are thought to predate even the oldest civilizations.

Points of Interest:

- **The Shattered Obelisk**: A towering, fractured stone spire that hums faintly with magical energy. Its fragments are scattered across the cliffs, some embedded deep in the rock.
- **Echoing Caverns**: A network of caves beneath the Reach, said to lead to ancient chambers. Unnatural sounds often echo from within.

3. The Greywater River

A fast-moving river that cuts through the region, originating in the Mistwood Hills to the northeast and flowing into the sea at Driftmoor. The river is vital for both irrigation and transportation. The river is home to trout, otters, and kingfishers, but strange, shadowy creatures have been seen skulking near its banks in recent months.

Landmarks:

- **The Old Mill**: A crumbling stone mill a few miles upriver, now operating to mill the recent harvest. The Haverstead family runs the mill.

- **Willowford Bridge**: A sturdy wooden bridge crossing the river, often watched by a farmer who charges a modest toll.

4. The Mistwood Hills

Rolling hills covered in dense, fog-laden forests that stretch northeast of Driftmoor. The Mistwood is known for its eerie atmosphere and towering pines. Hunters and loggers speak of vanishing paths, strange whispers, and shadowy figures deeper in the woods. Few venture far without good reason.

Points of Interest:

- **The Old Watchtower**: A crumbling stone tower on a hilltop, once used to spot incoming raiders. It's now overgrown and abandoned, but it offers a clear view of the region.
- **Fey Glade**: Hidden deep in the Mistwood, this glade is said to shimmer with faint light and strange, otherworldly energy.

5. The Azure Sea

A cold, rocky coastline with strong tides and unpredictable weather. Driftmoor's harbor is one of the few safe spots for fishing boats and trade vessels in the area.

Notable Features:

- **Sea Stacks**: Tall, isolated rock formations rising from the water near the shore. Legends say the sea stacks were once giants turned to stone.
- **The Drowned Isle**: A partially submerged island visible only during low tide. Fisherfolk claim it's cursed, and shadowy shapes have been spotted around it at night.

6. The Plains of Stonehearth

Windswept grasslands dotted with rocky outcroppings and small caves, located southeast of Driftmoor. These plains are used for grazing sheep and goats but are sparsely populated. Shadowbeasts have been sighted here, preying on livestock and unwary travelers.

Environmental Challenges

- Unpredictable Weather: Coastal storms roll in quickly, bringing heavy rain and strong winds that can make travel dangerous.
- Treacherous Terrain: The cliffs of the Obelisk Reach and the sea stacks near the coast are perilous, with crumbling edges and slippery surfaces.
- Wildlife and Threats: The region is home to wolves, giant crabs near the coast, and now, Shadowbeasts.

Key NPCs:

Elyssa Moonglow (Quest Giver):

- High Elf scholar and historian.
- Determined but anxious about the obelisk's power.
- Provides ancient maps and limited knowledge about the area.

Mayor Aldren Thorne:

- Gruff, no-nonsense leader of Driftmoor.
- Concerned about the safety of the town but skeptical of Elyssa's theories.
- Offers a reward if the adventurers can stop the disturbances.

Kelem Dustcloak:

- Shady human merchant who deals in rare artifacts.
- Secretly harvesting pieces of the obelisk to sell on the black market.
- May provide useful information… for a price.

The Adventure Outline:

ACT-1: Arrival in Driftmoor

Each member of the party has their own reasons for traveling through the frontier region of Driftmoor. Though they began as strangers, their paths will converge due to a common threat—and a common opportunity.
The party arrives in town separately and hears of the disturbances firsthand (e.g., moving shadows, a stolen cow discovered miles away, or eerie symbols in the dirt). They gather clues by speaking to locals, including a farmer whose field was marked by glowing runes. They learn that the obelisk has been rumored to hold a powerful ancient spirit—one that may not be friendly.

Wayne is Thorgrim Stoneheart (Dwarf Fighter)

Thorgrim was traveling through the region as a self-imposed exile from his homeland, taking odd mercenary jobs to stay afloat. While staying at the Ironhoof Forge, he was told about the obelisk and the troubles in Driftmoor. Recognizing the dangers such disturbances might pose to innocent people, Thorgrim decided to investigate.

Nestled in the shadow of Ironhoof Forge, Thorgrim's lean-to is a simple, practical shelter made from thick canvas stretched over sturdy wooden poles. The structure leans against the stable's rear wall, providing extra windbreak against the salty coastal breeze. A small fire pit, ringed with carefully arranged stones, sits a few feet away, its embers glowing faintly from Thorgrim's earlier attempts at cooking.

His belongings are sparse and utilitarian: a bedroll folded neatly in one corner, a small sack containing his travel rations and a whetstone, and his great sword propped securely against the stable wall. The smell of hay and iron from the forge mingles with the faint scent of smoke, giving the area a rugged, comforting atmosphere. Thorgrim spends his evenings here sharpening his weapons, watching the stars, and keeping to himself unless approached.

Kristin is Seraphina Duskwhisper (Half-Elf Rogue)

Seraphina was already in Driftmoor, lying low after a botched heist in a nearby town. She had been working with a group of local thieves, but her arcane slip-up during the job drew too much attention.

Seraphina has claimed one of the small upstairs rooms at The Broken Lantern Tavern, paying her rent in advance with coins earned through gambling and small cons around town. Her room is modest but tidy, with a simple wooden bed, a small desk cluttered with scraps of paper covered in half-finished plans, and a sturdy chest where she keeps her valuables locked away. A few faint scorch marks on the desk hint at occasional arcane experiments gone wrong.

In the evenings, Seraphina can usually be found downstairs, leaning back in one of the shadowy booths near the edge of the room. She engages in quiet, friendly games of dice or cards with locals and travelers, often letting others win just enough to keep them coming back. Despite her apparent nonchalance, her sharp eyes rarely miss a tell, and her quick hands make her adept at shifting the odds in her favor when the stakes get high.

While most patrons think she's just a clever drifter, a few have started to wonder how she always seems to walk away with more coin than she came in with. Tess, the tavern owner, keeps a watchful eye on her activities, allowing the games to continue as long as no real trouble arises.

Rose is Aeliana Moonglade (Wood Elf Ranger)

Aeliana was traveling in the forests near Driftmoor. She heard from the small creatures that foul creatures were about and saw their presence as a sign that something was deeply wrong with the natural order. Aeliana's camp is tucked into a small clearing deep in the Mistwood Hills, where tall pines and thick underbrush provide both cover and a sense of serenity. A lean-to fashioned from sturdy branches and a worn canvas tarp shelters her from the elements, while a carefully tended fire pit, surrounded by smooth river stones, gives off just enough warmth and light to be useful without drawing too much attention. Her belongings are minimal: a well-used bedroll, a small satchel of rations and tools, and a bow propped against a nearby tree. Aeliana's camp is as quiet and unassuming as she is, blending seamlessly with the wilderness around her, and the faint sound of a bubbling creek nearby completes the tranquil scene.

A small squirrel has been coming by often to chatter and make eye contact and seems not to be afraid of her.

Jim is Father Lilar Hearthson (Human Cleric)

The late afternoon sun casts a warm, golden light over the quiet countryside as Lilar Hearthsong walks along a dirt path that winds parallel to the Greywater River, his faithful burro plodding along beside him. The burro carries a simple wooden pack saddle laden with Lilar's modest belongings: a small sack of dried rations, a bedroll, a weathered holy symbol of Pelor, and several clay jars filled with salves and herbs he's gathered on his journey.

On either side of the river, the fields stretch out in neat rows, dotted with farmers tending to their crops of barley and root vegetables. The air is rich with the earthy smell of freshly tilled soil, mixed with the faint scent of wildflowers blooming along the riverbanks. The burro occasionally snorts and pauses to nibble at the grass, forcing Lilar to stop and pat its neck affectionately before urging it onward.

Lilar hums a quiet hymn as he walks, the melody blending with the gentle gurgle of the river and the distant calls of birds. Though the scene is peaceful, Lilar's sharp eyes scan the fields and treelines, wary of the growing unease that has gripped the region. He pauses briefly to draw a drink from the cool, clear river, offering a handful of water to the burro as well, before continuing west toward Driftmoor.

Up ahead he can see an old mill with its water wheel slowly turning.

Neala is Kaelin Brightspark (Halfling Bard)

Kaelin was performing at a roadside tavern near Driftmoor, entertaining a crowd of travelers and locals with a lively tune about a "haunted obelisk." This song was no coincidence; Kaelin had heard rumors about the strange disturbances in Driftmoor and saw an opportunity to weave a tale worth performing. She was secretly angling for patrons who might pay for her unique skills—be it with music, diplomacy, or clever deception. She's been staying in a room upstairs at the Broken Lantern for a day or so.

Varrak Ironflame (Sorcerer)

Varrak had been wandering for months, seeking knowledge and relics to enhance his arcane understanding. The shattered obelisk intrigued them; its fragments were rumored to contain immense magical energy. Varrak heard about Driftmoor through a traveling merchant. He has been staying at the Weary Traveler

Sister Amara Solbright (Human Cleric)

Amara was sent to Driftmoor by her church after news of the disturbances reached her order. Viewing the obelisk as a possible source of evil, she set out to investigate and assist the locals.

For the past few weeks, she has been staying in a modest guest room at The Beacon, the small stone church that serves as Driftmoor's spiritual center. The room is simple, with whitewashed walls, a narrow wooden bed, a small writing desk, and a single window that overlooks the herb garden behind the church. The faint scent of lavender and sage drifts in through the window, mingling with the ever-present aroma of beeswax candles burning in the chapel below.

Amara spends her mornings assisting Father Elden Greybeard with the daily upkeep of the church and tending to villagers in need of comfort or healing. Though the aging priest's movements are slow, his wisdom and gentle demeanor have earned Amara's deep respect, and she often seeks his counsel as she wrestles with her own uncertainties. She has also struck up a tentative friendship with Mira, the fiery young acolyte, offering gentle encouragement to bolster the girl's growing confidence in her divine abilities.

ACT-2: Exploring the Town

Players roll all dice to determine initial GPs and then can go shopping if they wish

Each player has a turn or two to explore the town, visiting any of the shops and talking with any of the proprietors. All shops have proprietors who may provide helpful information. Some shops have goods to sell that may be of use to the adventurers:

- The Mercantile "Salt and Iron"
- The Apothecary "The Bitter Remedy"
- Stable & Blacksmith "Ironhoof Forge"
- The Pawn Shop "Golden Trinket"
- Kalem Duskcloak's Shop "Duskcloak's Curios"

ACT-3: The Evening at The Broken Lantern

Players all assemble at the tavern after hearing about the coming evening's performance during their exploration of the town

The Broken Lantern Tavern is alive with warmth and energy as villagers and adventurers gather to unwind after a day's labor. The evening has drawn a lively crowd, filling the rustic wooden room with the hum of conversation and the clinking of mugs. The scent of lamb stew and freshly baked bread wafts through the air, mingling with the tang of spilled ale.

At the center of attention is Kaelin Brightspark, perched confidently on the small stage in the corner, illuminated by the flickering glow of oil lamps and the crackling hearth. Her lute gleams faintly in the warm light, and the halfling's nimble fingers dance across the strings as she tunes the instrument. A cheeky grin spreads across her face as she

banters with the audience, drawing a chorus of chuckles and cheers before launching into her first song.

The patrons are an eclectic mix:

- **Farmers and Fisherfolk**: Seated at the long, sturdy tables, they clap along with the music, mugs of Driftmoor Ale in hand. Their faces are weathered but relaxed, eager for a reprieve from their daily grind.
- **Adventurers**: Spread throughout the room, the adventurers are a striking presence, their gear polished and weapons sheathed. They exchange occasional glances, appreciating Kaelin's charm while keeping an ear out for any useful chatter.
- **Tess Malwin** (the owner): Tess moves between tables with the ease of a seasoned host, refilling drinks and exchanging sly remarks with regulars, her sharp eye ensuring no trouble brews.

Kaelin's voice carries over the murmur of the crowd, weaving tales of distant lands, heroic deeds, and romantic mischief. Her humor and wit draw frequent laughter, and she takes breaks between songs to trade quips and light-hearted insults with the more boisterous patrons.

Kaelin roleplay?

Meanwhile, subtle interactions occur across the room:

More character roleplay?

- **Seraphina**: Sitting in a shadowed booth, rolling dice with a group of farmers, her sly smile hinting that she's having more luck than her opponents.
- **Thorgrim**: Nursing a heavy mug of cider near the hearth, nodding appreciatively to Kaelin's performance while keeping a watchful eye on the crowd.
- **Amara**: Sitting quietly at a corner table with Father Greybeard, smiling faintly as she sips tea and listens to the music, a rare moment of relaxation for her.
- **Lilar**: Standing near the back with his burro tethered outside, chuckling quietly at Kaelin's humor and chatting with a nearby farmer about the coming winter.
- **(Varrak)**: An older man in a long cloak and slouchy hat is leaning against the bar with his arms crossed. His features are faintly illuminated by the lanternlight, his expression unreadable as he listens intently to the stories Kaelin weaves.
- **The Haverstead Family**: As the cheerful music and Kaelin's lively performance fill the room, the Haverstead family sits quietly in one of the tavern's corner booths, enjoying a rare evening out together. Gregan, the stoic father, leans back against the wooden bench, his thick arms crossed as he occasionally nods to the rhythm of the music. Beside him, Mara, his wife, smiles warmly, her hands resting protectively on her infant daughter, Isla, who is bundled in a soft blanket and gently dozing despite the noise. Davin, the teenage son, watches Kaelin intently,

a look of admiration on his face, while Tessa, his younger sister, sways slightly in her seat, mouthing the words to a familiar ballad.

The tavern feels like the heart of Driftmoor tonight—a rare moment of joy and community, though the underlying tension of the growing shadows outside lingers in the back of everyone's minds. For now, however, the music and laughter drown out the darkness.

Players chat among themselves as role play really begins among them

The Haversteads Depart

As Kaelin transitions into another upbeat tune, Gregan shifts uncomfortably and leans toward Mara, muttering something that only his family can hear. Mara nods, her smile fading slightly, and she begins gathering their belongings. Davin looks disappointed but doesn't argue, and Tessa lets out a soft groan, casting a longing glance toward the stage.

The family rises as discreetly as they can, Gregan leading the way toward the door with his usual lumbering gait. Mara follows close behind, cradling Isla as the baby stirs and whimpers faintly, the blanket pulled snug against the cool night air. Davin lingers just a moment longer, tossing a wistful glance back at Kaelin before hurrying to catch up, and Tessa trails after them, her small boots tapping lightly on the wooden floor.

As they make their way to the exit, the jovial atmosphere of the tavern doesn't falter, though a few patrons glance their way with curious expressions. **Tess Malwin**, ever watchful, raises an eyebrow from behind the bar and mutters something under her breath as she wipes a mug clean. **Thorgrim**, near the hearth, shifts his attention from Kaelin to the family, his sharp eyes narrowing slightly as he notes their departure. **Seraphina**, mid-dice roll in her booth, also catches the movement, her instincts whispering that something about their timing feels… off.

The door swings shut behind the Haversteads, and for a brief moment, the cold wind from outside lingers in the air before the warmth of the tavern reclaims the space. Kaelin's music carries on, but the subtle departure of the family leaves a faint ripple of unease in the hearts of those paying attention.

ACT-4: A Cry from Outside

The lively atmosphere in the Broken Lantern is shattered in an instant. The sharp, desperate shriek from outside pierces through Kaelin's performance, silencing the crowd mid-laugh. Chairs scrape against the wooden floor as a few patrons rise from their seats in confusion, heads turning toward the door. Before anyone can react further, the door slams open, and **Gregan** Haverstead stumbles into the tavern, his broad frame silhouetted against the dim evening light.

His shirt is in tatters, claw marks raking across his chest and arms, the faint glimmer of blood catching the flickering lanternlight. His face is pale, his expression twisted with terror and rage. His breath comes in heaving gasps as his eyes dart around the room, wild and pleading.

"*They've taken my baby!*" he bellows, his voice cracking under the weight of his desperation. "*The shadows—they came out of nowhere! They grabbed Isla and are dragging her towards the woods!*"

The room erupts into chaos. Patrons murmur in alarm, some shouting questions, others scrambling to get out of their seats. **Mara** Haverstead stumbles in behind **Gregan**, clutching **Tessa** tightly to her side. The young girl is sobbing uncontrollably, her face buried in her mother's skirts, while **Davin**, pale as a ghost, hovers behind them, his fists clenched uselessly.

Tess Malwin, the tavern owner, slams her mug on the bar, silencing the growing panic. "Quiet! Let the man speak!" she snaps, her sharp voice cutting through the noise. All eyes turn back to Gregan, who grips the edge of a nearby table for support, his broad chest heaving.

"*They came from the edge of town*," **Gregan** says, his voice hoarse but steadying as he speaks. "*Dark shapes, like the shadows themselves come alive. I—I tried to fight them off, but they were too fast. Too strong. They took Isla and vanished towards the river before I could stop them.*"

Roll initiative and allow players to describe their actions or default to examples below if necessary

Thorgrim, who had already risen from his seat when the shriek echoed, steps forward, his heavy boots thudding against the floor. "*Shadows, you say? Sounds like beasts I have fought before,*" he growls, his hand instinctively moving to the hilt of his axe. "*Where did they go*?"

Gregan points a trembling hand toward the door. "*To the river! Across the bridge!*" he spits, his voice cracking again. "*Please—help me get my daughter back!*"

The room is still for a moment, the weight of Gregan's words sinking in. Then a cleric, **Amara** rises, her face a mask of resolve. "*We must go. If these are Shadowbeasts, then we cannot delay,*" she says firmly, looking to the others.

Kaelin hops down from the stage, her lute still slung across her back. "*Well*," she says with a grim smile, "*looks like the encore is happening outside tonight*."

Seraphina stands from her booth, adjusting the straps on her quiver. "*I've seen enough to know those things don't wait around. We need to move fast.*"

The adventurers spring into action, gathering their weapons and gear as **Gregan** staggers toward them. "*I'll show you the way!*" he insists, his voice desperate.

Tess, standing behind the bar, calls out, "*You lot better come back alive—and bring that baby with you!*"

The adventurers rush into the cool night air, the cries of the Haverstead family fading as they leave the safety of the tavern and head toward the river bridge and the woods beyond.

ACT-5: The Bridge and the Faerie Fire

The adventurers charge out into the cool night air, following Gregan Haverstead as he stumbles ahead toward the bridge over the Greywater River, his face pale and streaked with desperation. The moonlight casts faint, silvery outlines on the path, but the shadows ahead under the trees ahead seem to writhe unnaturally, unnerving even the bravest among the group. The faint but piercing cries of baby Isla echo through the night, coming from farther towards the woods on the far side of the bridge. It's too dark for the party to see any more.

Time to review the Shadowbeast's profile and each player's strengths, weaknesses and abilities. Ask each player to list their AC, HPs, weapons and spells. Explain as needed.

Shadowbeasts:

Shadowbeasts are creatures formed from living darkness, tied to the fractured magic of the obelisk. They are eerie, semi-corporeal predators that stalk the wilderness near Driftmoor and attack without warning. These creatures thrive in dim light or darkness, where they blend into the shadows, becoming almost impossible to detect until they strike.
Shadowbeasts are unnerving to behold, their bodies appearing as swirling, semi-corporeal masses of shadow shaped vaguely like large predatory cats or wolves. Their glowing, white, pupil-less eyes are the only features that stand out in the dark. Their movements are silent, and their presence is often accompanied by a faint chill in the air and the unsettling sensation of being watched.

Race: Medium Monstrosity
Alignment: Neutral Evil
Armor Class: 12
Hit Points: 16 (3d8 + 3)
Speed: 40 ft
Challenge: ½ (100 XP)

Stats:

- Strength: 6 (-2)
- Dexterity: 14 (+2)
- Constitution: 13 (+1)
- Intelligence: 6 (-2)
- Wisdom: 10
- Charisma: 8 (-1)

Skills:

- Dexterity (Stealth) +4, +6 in dim light or darkness

Damage Resistances:

- Half damage: Bludgeoning, Piercing, and Slashing from Nonmagical Weapons

Damage Vulnerabilities:

- Double damage: Radiant

Condition Immunities:

- Charmed
- Frightened

Party Review:

- **Thorgrim (AC 18+2 HP 13)**: Usually positioned at the front to charge into melee combat, his 18+2 AC makes him impossible for the Shadowbeasts to hit (Strength -2). His battle axe and crossbow hits seem to pierce thin air, however, and do only half their usual 1d8 damage to these creatures.
- **Lilar (AC 12+2 HP 10)**: Can cast **Guiding Bolt** (4d6@120ft), **Healing Word** (1d4+1 healing HPs) and can bolster the party with **Bless** (3x1d4 to hit/save) then moving forward for direct combat. His mace and staff will also do half its normal 1d6 bludgeoning damage to these creatures.
- **Seraphina (AC 11 HP 9) and Aeliana (AC 14 HP 12)**: With their bows, they have a clear line of sight on the beasts and can deal solid damage from a distance. Their 2 arrows per round normally do 1d4 of damage, however they do only half their normal damage to these creatures. Aeliana's short sword will also do half its normal 1d6 damage.

- **Kaelin (AC 11 HP 9):** Can cast **Faerie Fire** to illuminate the scene in a blue, green or violet light. Any revealed creatures will have ***disadvantage*** in combat and be outlined in light while it lasts. This will also grant the party ***advantage*** on attacks against them. Next rounds she can cast **Bardic Inspiration** (+1d6 to hit/save for one player) or **Cure Wounds** (1d6) to heal one player's HPs. Her rapier will only do half its normal 1d6 damage to these creatures.

Explain: Players having advantage roll 2d20 for attacks and take highest value. Creatures with disadvantage roll 2d20 and take the lowest value.

- **(Amara (AC 12+2 HP 11))**: Can cast **Healing Word** (1d4+1 HPs) spell and bolster the party with **Bless** (3x1d4 to hit/save) while keeping Gregan calm or moving forward for combat. Her mace and sling will do half their normal 1d6 and 1d4 bludgeoning damage to these creatures.
- **(Varrak (AC 8 HP 8))**: Can cast **Magic Missile**, doing 3x1d4+1 or **Burning Hands** to do 3d6 damage. He can also cast **Mage Armor** on one individual (Seraphina, Kaelin or even Gregan) to give them AC 13 protection. His quarterstaff will do half its 1d6 bludgeoning damage to these creatures.

Players roll initiative and describe their next actions.

Does Kaelin cast Faerie Fire?

Kaelin, her sharp halfling ears attuned to the cries, sprints ahead with surprising speed, her lute bouncing against her back. "*Hold on!*" she shouts over their shoulder to the others. "*I've got a trick for this!*"

As they reach the center of the bridge, Kaelin stops abruptly, scanning the shadows ahead. The baby's cries grow louder, almost agonizing in their terror, but there's still no sign of movement—only the oppressive darkness of the woods beyond. Gritting her teeth, Kaelin pulls out a small silver charm from her belt, whispering a few quick words in an old, lilting tongue: "*Anal natrach! Outh vas bethoud!*"

Kaelin raises her hand, and **Faerie Fire** bursts forth in a radiant shimmer of violet-blue light, sweeping toward the direction of the baby's cries. The glowing light washes over the area, illuminating the shadows with an eerie brilliance.

What the Faerie Fire Reveals

As the **Faerie Fire** settles, several shapes are suddenly thrown into sharp, glowing relief:

- **A Shadowbeast** looms just inside the tree line on the far side of the bridge, its grotesque, amorphous form writhing with unnatural shadows that ripple as if alive. It is holding a squirming, glowing bundle in its claws—the baby!
- **A Second Shadowbeast** crouches by the edge of the riverbank. The violet-blue light clings to its form, outlining its claws and fanged maw with terrifying clarity. It hisses as the light exposes it, its yellow eyes narrowing in anger. Its glowing outline makes it an easy target.
- The trees and underbrush further into the woods glow faintly where the Faerie Fire spreads, making it clear the Shadowbeasts are not alone—there's movement in the foliage, hinting at more shadowy figures that wait.

A Third Shadowbeast steps forward to defend the bridgehead. It is not outlined by the Faerie Fire.

ACT-6: Melee Combat Begins

Battlefield Setup:

- **The Bridge**: The bridge spans 30 feet over the river, with sturdy wooden railings but limited width, forcing the party into double-file, tight formations.
- **Shadowbeast 1** (Tree line): 20 feet beyond the bridge, holding the baby. Moving towards the tree line.
- **Shadowbeast 2** (Riverbank): 10 feet beyond the bridge, this beast is preparing to pounce on anyone who crosses.
- **Additional Shadowbeasts**: The faint movement in the glowing underbrush suggests at least 1-2 more beasts lurking just out of range of the Faerie Fire.

Roll initiative for the 3 Shadowbeasts. Melee begins with them at disadvantage.

Shadowbeast Reaction

The Shadowbeast holding the baby snarls at being exposed and retreats further towards the woods, dragging Isla with it. The other Shadowbeasts, emboldened by their numbers, start to circle toward the bridge, attempting to block the adventurers' advance.

- Shadowbeast A (AC 12 HP 16)
- Shadowbeast B (AC 12 HP 16)
- Shadowbeast C (AC 12 HP 16)

Narrative Hook

Gregan, still near the rear of the party, shouts in desperation, "Don't let them take her any further! Please!" as townsfolk begin to head towards the bridge with torches, pitchforks, scythes and axes.

Combat begins with the Shadowbeasts attempting to delay the party and force them into a dangerous pursuit. The adventurers must decide whether to focus on the beasts blocking the bridge or press ahead to rescue Isla from the creatures retreating into the woods.

Melee continues

ACT-7: Where Do We Go from Here

The battle has ended with a mixed result: Two or three Shadowbeasts have been killed but the one carrying baby Isla has escaped into the dark forest with the rest of the beasts. The party and townspeople return to the tavern to regroup.

The Broken Lantern's doors swing shut behind the adventurers as the echoes of battle fade, leaving only the hurried whispers of frightened townsfolk in their wake. The tavern is no longer filled with laughter and music but with the sharp tang of fear. The party has defeated some of the Shadowbeasts, but the most critical enemy—the one that stole baby Isla—has slipped away into the dense night-shrouded forest beyond the bridge.

Gregan Haverstead stands at the tavern's entrance, fists clenched at his sides, eyes darting between the adventurers. "Are we going after her now, or do we wait for first light?" he demands, his voice hoarse from shouting.

The Choice:

- Pursue Now (Night Hunt) – The beast's tracks are fresh, and waiting might mean losing Isla forever. However, the forest is dangerous at night, and the Queen's influence could be stronger in the darkness.
- Wait Until Dawn – With daylight, visibility improves, and the party can gather supplies. But the shadowbeast may retreat deeper into the forest or reach wherever it was taking Isla.

Roleplay discussion of alternatives

ACT-8: The Mayor's Reward

Mayor Aldren Thorne arrives, his usually calm and composed demeanor shaken. Aldren is a stout, broad-shouldered human man in his mid-50s, with weathered skin, thinning gray hair, and a perpetually furrowed brow. His practical clothing—sturdy boots, a wool coat, and a wide-brimmed hat—is more suited to a farmer or fisherman than a politician. Aldren is a man of the people, though his blunt demeanor and no-nonsense attitude often come across as curt. He cares deeply for Driftmoor and its people, though he's slow to trust outsiders and quick to suspect ulterior motives.

Aldren offers a substantial reward for the baby's return, promising gold, land rights, or even titles for the heroes. The reward raises tension among the townsfolk—many see it as proof of Driftmoor's growing peril, and others begin to wonder how much their mayor is truly hiding.

Mayor Thorne is a pragmatic and calculating leader, more concerned with keeping Driftmoor stable than moral debates. He sees the party as a necessary asset—if they succeed, he wants them on his side for the future. Depending on their actions, he offers incentives to ensure they're rewarded—but also tied to the town in some way.

Gold & Material Rewards

- Base Reward: 250 GP per adventurer (negotiable up to 400 GP each if they press him).

- Tangible Goods: If the party haggles or the town's coffers are low, he can offer valuable goods instead of straight gold, such as:
    i. A chest of silver ingots (worth 500 GP, but harder to spend without drawing attention).
    ii. A fine horse and tack (good for travel or resale).
    iii. A sealed writ promising discounted goods at the Driftmoor Mercantile for the next year.

Land & Property Rights

- If the party expresses interest in settling or staying in Driftmoor, the mayor offers:
- Ownership of an Abandoned Farmstead → A small home with land outside town (could be developed into a base).
- A Room at the Broken Lantern for Life → Pre-paid lodging, making the tavern their default home base.
- A Future Share in Local Trade → The right to a small percentage of dock or trade profits, ensuring a steady passive income.

Authority & Recognition

- Honorary Titles - The party is named "Defenders of Driftmoor", recognized in town records, and given a ceremonial badge of office.
- Local Influence - They gain access to exclusive town meetings, letting them shape Driftmoor's future policies (such as defenses, taxes, or militia expansion).
- Political Favor - The mayor hints that if Driftmoor grows, he could use their support to push for higher political standing—perhaps one day becoming a regional power.

Special Equipment & Gifts

The mayor isn't magically inclined, but he can arrange for:

- An Heirloom Weapon or Armor → A finely made (non-magical) longsword or chainmail from his family's collection.
- Access to the Town's Best Craftsmanship → A custom-fit suit of armor or weapon upgrade at Ironhoof Forge.
- A Single Magical Item from Elyssa (only if she approves) → She may gift them a minor enchanted item, but only if she trusts them.

- The Mayor's Hidden Agendas (Optional Plot Hooks)
    - If the party impresses him, he may subtly try to recruit them as Driftmoor's enforcers.
    - If the cultists were townsfolk, he may ask the party to help him cover it up to avoid public panic.
    - If the obelisk remains unstable, he may ask the party to keep that fact quiet, fearing it will drive people away from Driftmoor.

How This Plays into the Ending

- If the party takes the gold & leaves, they are paid heroes but not tied to the town.
- If they accept property or status, they become part of Driftmoor, leading to future entanglements.
- If they suspect the mayor has secrets, they might dig deeper into the town's true history.

More roleplay discussion to respond to mayor's offers

ACT-9: Elyssa's Arrival & the Tale About the Queen

As the party deliberates, a hush falls over the room when Elyssa Moonglow steps inside. Elyssa is a tall, elegant high elf with silver hair tied back in a loose braid and piercing blue eyes. Her simple, practical robes are often stained with ink or dust. Elyssa is deeply dedicated to her research, sometimes to the point of obsession. Her sharp intellect allows her to notice details others miss, but her blunt manner can alienate those unused to her intensity. Despite her scholarly aloofness, she genuinely wants to protect Driftmoor and its people, even if they don't trust her methods.

She walks in with measured grace, her silver-blue robes whispering against the tavern floor, and her face is unusually grave. "*The Queen of Chains*," she murmurs, more to herself than the crowd. "*She's waking*."

Elyssa unrolls an ancient parchment, revealing sketches of an enormous stone obelisk wrapped in ethereal chains, arcane symbols etched along its surface. She explains that the obelisk was never just a monument—it was a prison. Long ago, a cabal of sorcerers and holy warriors sealed a demon known as the **Queen of Chains** beneath it, binding her within the stones with wards of divine light and ancient sigils.

But the seals have weakened, the obelisk has shattered and the Shadowbeasts are her first agents—creatures of pure nightmare, clawing their way into reality to prepare for their Queen's return.

- The Queen needs a vessel to fully manifest—a mortal to anchor her spirit in the world.
- The stolen infant might be part of the final ritual to break the chains.
- If the Queen is reborn, not even Driftmoor will be left standing.

The Need for Magical Artifacts

Recognizing the danger of the cult and the Queen's impending release, Elyssa Moonglow agrees to lend the party a few magical items—but she makes it clear that these are not gifts. They must be returned once the crisis is over, or she will seek them out personally.

As she hands over the items, she says:

"*This is not just your fight. These artifacts carry the wisdom of those who came before us. Use them well… and do not make me regret this trust*."

1. The Sunlight Brand (Magical Weapon – Loaned to a Frontline Fighter)

- Item Type: Magical Longsword (or Battleaxe if Thorgrim wields it)
- Appearance: A silver-forged weapon with a faint golden shimmer running along its edge. The hilt is inlaid with runes of radiant protection.
- Effects:
  - +1 to Attack and Damage Rolls.
  - Deals an extra 1d4 Radiant Damage to fiends, undead, and shadow creatures.
  - Light in the Dark: The weapon glows like a torch when within 30 feet of a fiend or undead, revealing hidden creatures.
- How It Helps: The extra radiant damage and revealing glow are direct counters to the Shadowbeasts and cultists.

2. Aegis of the First Ward (Protective Amulet – Loaned to a Spellcaster or Support Role)

- Item Type: Magical Amulet
- Appearance: A silver pendant in the shape of a broken chain, faintly pulsing with warmth.
- Effects:
  - Once per long rest, the wearer can resist a possession or mind control attempt (Advantage on saving throws against such effects).
  - If reduced to 0 HP, the amulet shatters instead, restoring the wearer to 1 HP instead of falling unconscious.
- How It Helps:
  - Prevents possession or mental influence from the Queen's whispers.
  - Offers a second chance for a party member who might otherwise die in battle.

3. Moonglow's Binding Salts (1-Time Use – Given to a Tactician or Resourceful Player)

- Item Type: Alchemical Tool
- Appearance: A small leather pouch filled with shimmering white powder, glowing faintly under moonlight.
- Effects:
  - Throwing the salts (Action, 10 ft range) interrupts any ongoing dark magic or summoning ritual in a 10-foot radius.
  - Any creature tethered to an extraplanar entity (like a cultist linked to the Queen) takes 2d6 radiant damage and must make a DC 12 Constitution save or be stunned for 1 round.
  - Can weaken chains of dark influence, such as cutting the tether between Isla and the Queen's ritual.
- How It Helps:

- This can be a clutch move to halt the Queen's summoning mid-fight or disable the cultists momentarily.
- Can free Isla safely, preventing her from becoming the Queen's vessel.

Elyssa's Warning

"*I am giving you these because I believe in you… but power is a dangerous thing. Do not let it corrupt you, as it did those who came before.*"

She then looks each adventurer in the eye, making sure they understand the responsibility they now bear.

How This Helps Balance the Final Fight

- Radiant Damage from the **Sunlight Brand** helps against Shadowbeasts and Raleth's necrotic magic.
- The **Amulet** prevents mind control/possession—important for resisting the Queen's influence.
- The **Binding Salts** can be used tactically to interrupt the ritual or weaken the cultists.

To stop the Queen, brute force will not be enough. The party is still not strong enough to defeat her without stronger magic. **Elyssa** says that **Kalem Dustcloak**, the town's shadiest merchant of artifacts and curios, may have something that could restore the seals—or at least weaken the Queen's influence. However, Kalem never gives anything for free.

The party will need to:

- Negotiate with Kalem Dustcloak – He may have a chain-link relic or fragments of the original sealing runes, but what price will he demand?
- Track Isla's captor – Whether now or at dawn, they must follow the trail before it vanishes.
- Prepare for the Queen's Next Move – Even if they save Isla, the obelisk's seals are failing. How much time do they truly have before the Queen emerges?

More roleplay discussion to visit Kalem and/or determine next moves

ACT-10: Kalem Dustcloak's Artifacts for Sale

Kalem Dustcloak sits in the shadowy corner of his cluttered shop, fingers steepled as he watches the adventurers with a knowing smirk. Kelem is a wiry, 47-year-old male half-elf with dark hair pulled into a messy ponytail and sharp, calculating eyes that always seem to be appraising everything around him. He wears a patched, hooded cloak that he never seems to remove, even indoors. He's charming but evasive. Kelem is quick with a smile and a quip but never looks you in the eye.

His establishment, a dimly lit curiosity shop filled with trinkets and forgotten relics, hums with an air of mystery. Among the treasures he offers, three stand out—each with ties to the arcane forces at work in Driftmoor's growing peril.

4. The Lantern of Revealing (400 GP)

- Description: A brass lantern with an intricately wrought handle, its glass panels faintly etched with runes that shimmer when the flame is lit.
- Properties: When lit, the Lantern of Revealing casts bright light for 30 feet and dim light for an additional 30 feet. Any invisible creatures or objects within its light are revealed for what they truly are.
- How It Helps: Shadowbeasts rely on darkness and concealment—this lantern will expose them, making them easier to fight and track.

5. The Chain of Warding (250 GP)

- Description: A rusted, iron chain coiled within a small wooden box lined with faded black velvet. Its links are engraved with ancient symbols, barely visible beneath layers of age and grime.
- Properties:
  - When wrapped around an object, the chain prevents extraplanar entities from interacting with it—including demons, spirits, and shadow creatures.
  - The chain can be broken or cut, but doing so releases a burst of energy that deals 3d6 radiant damage to any fiend or undead within 10 feet.
- How It Helps: The Queen's prison was built on binding magic. Placing this chain around the obelisk or on the captured infant Isla could disrupt the Queen's connection before she fully manifests.

6. The Tear of Eldrin (600 GP, Non-Negotiable)

- Description: A small crystal vial containing a single drop of glowing silver liquid. The vial itself is sealed with ancient elven sigils, and Kalem refuses to let anyone touch it directly.
- Properties:
  - When consumed or poured onto a sigil or binding rune, the Tear restores its original strength for 24 hours.
  - Drinking it grants protection from possession or mind control for 1 hour.
  - The Tear is incredibly rare, and Kalem warns that its effects are temporary but immensely powerful.
- How It Helps:
  - The Tear of Eldrin can restore the Queen's failing chains, giving the party more time to enact a permanent solution.
  - If the Queen attempts to possess someone, this prevents her from taking a vessel for a limited time.
  - Kalem won't haggle on this one—he knows its worth.

Roleplay haggling with Kalem to obtain the artifacts

Kalem's Price & Negotiation Hooks

Kalem isn't just going to let these rare and powerful items go cheaply. He offers three paths to obtaining them, each with consequences:

- Gold Payment – If the party has enough gold or valuables, Kalem will sell the items at the stated prices. However, 1250 GP is a steep price at 1st level.
- A Favor Owed – Kalem will lower the cost or even part with one item for free if the party agrees to retrieve something for him.
- Possible Task:
    - Retrieve a black iron key buried beneath the ruined chapel outside Driftmoor.
    - Investigate a smuggler's stash he hasn't been able to reach.
    - Find out why some of his contacts have disappeared near the Mistwood Hills.
- A Dark Bargain – Kalem has other interests beyond wealth. He might trade an artifact if a party member signs a contract, offers up a memory, or delivers an unknown parcel to a strange client.

How These Items Influence the Story

- The **Chain of Warding** is a direct countermeasure against the Queen. If placed around Isla or used at the obelisk, it can delay or disrupt her summoning.
- The **Tear of Eldrin** could buy the party time, but its temporary nature forces them to find a permanent solution.
- The **Lantern of Revealing** ensures no more Shadowbeasts can slip away unnoticed, and it prevents ambushes.

ACT-11: Tracking the Shadowbeasts

The party forms up in order of march. Who's on point? Tail guard? Squirrel? Worries of Shadowbeasts about?

- The party follows the Shadowbeast's trail through the dark woods, using the Lantern of Revealing (if they bought it) to expose lurking creatures.
- Along the way, they encounter twisted wildlife—birds frozen in mid-air, trees that drip black ichor—signs of the Queen's corruption. But nothing else moves.

Roleplay following the narrow path.

ACT-12: Shadowbeast War Party Detected Ahead

- If the squirrel is going ahead of the party to warn of dangers, it will tell the party of an approaching group of 6 Shadowbeasts coming towards them on the path.
    - They may attempt to hide in the shadows or do combat

- If not, then they are surprised

Hopefully they are prudent and elect to hide, else Melee ensues

- The party continues following the path and finally reaches a clearing in the forest

ACT-13: The Fey Glade

Deep within the forest lies the Fey Glade—a place of ancient magic, untouched by time. Here, the veil between realms is thin, allowing the whispers of the Feywild to bleed into the mortal world. Unlike the dark, foreboding stretches of the Mistwood, the Fey Glade is alive with an unnatural vibrancy—flowers glow with soft luminescence, the air hums with unseen melodies, and the very earth pulses with a quiet, rhythmic energy, as if breathing in tandem with the land itself.

At the center of the glade, a crystalline spring flows in a perfect circle, its waters unnaturally clear, reflecting not just the sky above, but glimpses of the Feywild itself. Will-o'-wisps flicker along the treetops, guiding or misleading travelers, and the towering silver-barked trees seem to shift subtly when unobserved, their branches curling like watchful sentinels.

The party must roll a Wisdom save or be drawn to the pool, gazing into it with their spirits being helplessly drawn in. While they gaze into the pool they may learn of the Legends & Rumors, see into their past or future actions or meet the Hidden Guardian.

Legends & Rumors

1. The Glade is a Place of Oaths – It is said that any promise sworn in the Fey Glade is bound by magic—a broken vow may call forth the wrath of unseen fey.
2. The Pool of Echoes – Those who gaze into the spring may see glimpses of their past, present, or possible futures, but they must beware—for the pool does not lie, but neither does it show the whole truth.
3. A Hidden Guardian – An ancient fey entity—perhaps a dryad, eladrin, or trickster spirit—watches over the glade, intervening when mortals disrespect its sanctity.
4. The Path to Elsewhere – On certain nights, under the right alignment of stars, the glade becomes a crossing point, allowing passage into the Feywild—for those bold or foolish enough to step through.
5. Cursed to Wander – Some say if one disrespects the glade, they may be cursed to walk in circles forever, never finding the way out until they offer something of true worth to the fey.

How the Party Might Use the Fey Glade

- A Place to Seek Visions – The Pool of Echoes may grant the adventurers a vision of the Queen of Chains' past or future, helping them understand her origins.
- A Site for a Powerful Ritual – If the party must rebind the Queen, the Fey Glade's inherent magic could be the key to sealing her away permanently.
- A Potential Ally or Threat – If a Fey Guardian resides here, it might aid the party in stopping the Queen—or demand a high price for its help.
- A Gateway to the Feywild – If the Queen's influence spreads, the Fey might intervene, seeing her as a threat to the balance between worlds.

Six paths exit the glade. Which will the party take?

ACT-14: The Ritual Site & Final Showdown

The party comes upon the obelisk in a clearing. Does the squirrel up ahead give them advance warning and surprise=advantage?

A cracked stone altar stands before the obelisk, covered in rusted chains. The air is thick with the scent of burning incense and decay, and the very ground beneath the altar seems warped by the ritual's growing influence. The monolith pulses with dark energy, and the chains wrapped around it are slowly beginning to unravel.

- A **Shadowbeast** holds **Isla** above the altar, a thin tendril of dark energy linking her to the monolith (AC-12 HP-16)
- Three cultists are deep in the throes of an arcane ritual
    - **Harbinger Raleth (Cult Leader)** is standing at the altar, arms raised, chanting in a guttural, ancient tongue that seems to vibrate in the adventurers' skulls. Holding a ceremonial dagger over Isla, the blade pulsating with black fire as he prepares to carve a sigil into the stone beneath her. His eyes are completely black, unfocused, as if he is in communion with the Queen herself.
    - **Sister Entha (Acolyte of Chains)** is kneeling before the altar, her arms raised toward the sky, chanting in unison with Raleth. Holding a black iron chain, slowly unraveling it, each link disintegrating into dark mist, symbolic of the Queen's prison breaking apart. Her lips are cracked and bleeding, but she continues to chant through the pain, an expression of rapturous devotion on her face.
    - **Brother Jareth (The Reluctant One)** is near the edge of the altar's platform, watching the baby with unease, his grip on his black dagger trembling. His chanting fades in and out, his gaze darting between Isla and the cult leaders, uncertainty warring with fear. He keeps glancing at the forest's edge, as if debating whether to flee or continue.
- A towering spectral figure looms above the altar, its form shifting like smoke yet anchored by ethereal chains that rattle and strain against unseen bindings.
    - **The Queen's** face is a hollowed void, save for two piercing, ember-like eyes that burn with unnatural hunger. Her form is draped in tattered veils of shadow, the remnants of a queenly gown woven from darkness itself.

The spectral chains wrapped around her limbs and torso seem half-broken, flickering between real and incorporeal, their sigils glowing with fading power.

- The air is unnaturally cold, and the Queen's whispering voice echoes in the minds of all present, planting seeds of doubt and fear
- If left uninterrupted, the ritual will reach completion soon, weakening the Queen's prison permanently

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Help the party to understand their alternatives: The chains binding the Queen are the true target. The Queen is not yet fully manifest—but her cultists are using Isla as a conduit to weaken the last of her bindings.

How the Adventurers Can Disrupt the Ritual

- *Attacking the cultists: Interrupts the chant, stopping the ritual.*
- *Using the **Binding Salts**: Immediately weakens the ritual's power.*
    - *Throwing the salts (Action, 10 ft range) interrupts any ongoing dark magic or summoning ritual in a 10-foot radius.*
    - *Any creature tethered to an extraplanar entity (like a cultist linked to the Queen) takes 2d6 radiant damage and must make a DC 12 Constitution save or be stunned for 1 round.*
    - *Can weaken chains of dark influence, such as cutting the tether between Isla and the Queen's ritual.*
- *Convincing Jareth to betray them: Breaks the ritual's flow, causing a backlash of energy.*
- *Destroy the Ritual Site. The adventurers use brute force (or the **Tear of Eldrin**) to sever the ritual, banishing the Queen's influence for now.*
- *Seal the Queen Permanently. **Using the Chain of Warding**, they bind the monolith again, restoring the prison's power.*
    - *If successful, the Queen is fully locked away—but at a cost (e.g., a PC must channel energy through themselves, taking a permanent scar or vision of the Queen's return).*
- *Bargain with the Queen (Darker Option). The Queen offers boons of dark power in exchange for allowing the ritual to continue partially, without Isla. If they accept, the party gains power—but a fragment of the Queen remains in the world, setting up a future campaign hook.*

The party executes their plan!

The Wraith Queen

When she sees the adventurers, her voice is a whisper of iron and silk, echoing in the minds of those who hear it: "*You struggle against the inevitable… but soon, you all shall kneel in my embrace.*" As she reaches out, her elongated fingers stretch like curling tendrils, leaving trails of dark energy in the air. The battlefield grows colder, and the very shadows seem to coil toward her, as if longing for release.

Party must roll Wisdom saving throws or be terrified = disadvantage

Harbinger Raleth (Cult Leader) is standing at the altar, arms raised, chanting in a guttural, ancient tongue that seems to vibrate in the adventurers' skulls.

- When he sees the adventurers, he turns with a slow, eerie calm and says: "*You cannot stop this. It has already begun!*"
- Stats:
  - AC: 13 (Ritual Leathers + Defensive Wards)
  - HP: 38 (7d8 + 7)
  - Resistances: Necrotic
  - Weaknesses: Radiant, Silvered Weapons (e.g. Sunlight Brand does extra 1d4)
- Abilities:
  - **Dark Benediction** (Recharges on 5-6) – Raleth lashes out with spectral chains, pulling one enemy 10 feet closer (DC 13 Strength save to resist).
  - **Blood Offering** (Bonus Action) – He slashes his own palm, losing 5 HP to strengthen an ally, giving +1d6 damage to a cultist or the Shadowbeast's next attack.
- Final Act (Reaction, 1/Day) – If reduced to 0 HP, he sacrifices himself, causing each enemy within 10 feet to make a DC 12 Constitution save or take 2d6 necrotic damage as the Queen's energy explodes from him.

Sister Entha (Acolyte of Chains) is kneeling before the altar, her arms raised toward the sky, chanting in unison with Raleth.

- When she sees the adventurers, she smiles serenely and whispers: "*You do not understand… we are setting her free, not summoning her.*"
- Stats:
  - AC: 12 (Tattered Robes + Protective Sigils)
  - HP: 22 (4d8 + 4)
  - Resistances: Psychic, Necrotic
  - Weaknesses: Radiant
- Abilities:
  - **Bloodletting Curse** (1/Turn) – Any creature she hits with her dagger suffers a wound that cannot be healed by magic until the Queen's influence is purged (e.g., the ritual is stopped, or she is killed).
  - **Wail of Submission** (Action, 1/Day) – Letting out an eerie scream, all creatures within 15 feet must make a DC 12 Wisdom save or suffer disadvantage on Wisdom saves for 1 minute.
  - **Dark Devotion** (Passive) – She cannot be frightened or charmed due to her utter faith in the Queen.

Brother Jareth (The Reluctant One) is near the edge of the altar's platform, watching the baby with unease, his grip on his dagger trembling.

- If the adventurers call out to him, he may hesitate, breaking the ritual's rhythm.

- Stats:
    - AC: 11 (Cult Robes, No True Protection)
    - HP: 16 (3d8 + 3)
    - Resistances: None
    - Weaknesses: Psychological Pressure – He can be persuaded or frightened into surrendering with a successful DC 12 Persuasion or Intimidation check (advantage if a cleric or paladin speaks to him).
- Abilities:
    - **Cracked Devotion** – His attacks have disadvantage if an ally is defeated, as his will begins to break.
    - **Shrouded Strike** – If attacking from hiding, he does extra 1d6 damage, but his attacks are weaker than the others'.
    - **Breaking Point** (Triggered Ability) – If he drops below 10 HP, he must make a DC 10 Wisdom save. On a fail, he panics and tries to flee.

How They Work in Battle

- Raleth controls the battlefield with chains and dark magic, but his sacrificial powers drain his own life.
- Entha is the most fanatical and aggressive, fighting to the bitter end.
- Jareth is a wildcard—if pressured, he may turn against the cult or flee.

Melee and/or other interventions occur

ACT-15: Epilogue: The Return to Driftmoor

The weary adventurers emerge from the shadowed forest, the distant glow of Driftmoor's lanterns a beacon of warmth after their long and harrowing journey. The wind carries the scent of salt and damp earth, the sea lapping gently at the shore beyond the hills. The echo of the Queen's whispers has faded, leaving only the rustling leaves and the rhythmic footfalls of the party as they step onto the worn dirt road leading back into town.

In one of the party's arms, baby Isla stirs but does not cry, her tiny fingers clinging instinctively to the fabric of their tunic. Gregan, Mara and Tessa Haverstead, having kept vigil outside the Broken Lantern, sprint toward them the moment they spot the party. Mara lets out a half-strangled sob, gathering her daughter into her arms, her relief palpable. Tessa, too overwhelmed to speak, clings to her father, burying her face in his side.

The villagers gather quickly, their expressions a mixture of awe, gratitude, and trepidation. News of the cult's defeat and the Queen's chains being renewed spreads in hushed whispers and exclamations, and though many cheer, some glance toward the

darkened horizon where the obelisk still looms—a reminder that evil can never truly be destroyed, only held at bay.

Mayor Aldren Thorne's Response

Mayor Aldren Thorne arrives, flanked by a pair of town guards, his usual composed expression betraying a hint of uncharacteristic tension. His eyes dart between the adventurers and the baby, lingering for a fraction of a second on the faint, lingering sigils burned into Isla's skin—marks that will fade with time, or perhaps not.

"Driftmoor owes you a great debt," he says at last, his voice steady, but his gaze sharp. "You have done what many would not dare. The cult is vanquished, the child is safe, and the Queen remains bound beneath her prison. That is enough for now."

He gestures to one of his men, who brings forward a heavy leather pouch, the unmistakable jingle of gold within. A promised reward, but also a calculated payment—an attempt to ensure their loyalty, or perhaps, their silence.

"Take this with our thanks," he continues, then lowers his voice, just enough that only the adventurers hear. "Driftmoor remembers those who defend it. But it also remembers those who stir up troubles best left buried. The obelisk remains… and so do its secrets. If you must speak of what transpired, speak carefully."

The words are not a threat, nor are they an invitation. They are simply a fact—a warning wrapped in gratitude.

Elyssa Moonglow's Gratitude & the Returned Artifacts

Later that night, in the quiet sanctuary of Elyssa Moonglow's dwelling, the elven scholar examines the items she loaned to the party, her fingers tracing their surfaces as though sensing the magic within.

She takes the **Sunlight Brand** first, lifting it slightly before exhaling a soft sigh. "This blade has done well in your hands," she murmurs. "It has touched true darkness and still holds the light. That is rare."

The **Aegis of the First Ward** follows, its faint glow flickering as she holds it to her chest. "The amulet still hums with the echoes of its purpose. That you return it intact tells me the worst did not come to pass." There is relief in her voice, but also caution—she knows that the Queen's hunger is eternal.

Finally, she uncorks the empty vial that once held the **Tear of Eldrin**, shaking her head with something between admiration and sorrow. “A relic lost, but for the right cause. To have wielded such power wisely is more valuable than any magic it contained.”

She sets the vial down gently and looks to the adventurers, her silver-blue eyes sharp yet warm.

“You have done well. But be warned—power like the Queen’s does not fade, it only waits. You have bought Driftmoor time, but time is all it is.” She pauses before offering a faint smile. “Still… if there is one thing I have learned, it is that heroes often appear where they are needed. And I suspect you will be needed again.”

With that, she dips her head in respect and gratitude, the flickering candlelight casting her expression in shifting shadows and gold.

Final Scene: The Broken Lantern

As the night deepens, the Broken Lantern Tavern is alive once more—not with fear, but with relief, laughter, and celebration. Tess Malwin, the ever-watchful tavern keeper, slides a round of drinks across the counter, her sharp gaze softer than usual. “You lot better drink up while you can,” she says with a smirk. “Who knows how long before some other damn fool stirs up trouble, eh?”

The mood is lighter, the tension of the past day slowly fading into the warmth of a firelit room, the clinking of mugs, and the rising melody of Kaelin Brightspark’s lute. The adventurers sit together, perhaps for the first time without the weight of the night pressing against them.

For now, Driftmoor is safe.

But the mark of the Queen remains—on the obelisk, in the echoes of Isla’s cries, and in the memories of those who have seen what lurks beyond the veil of reality.

And somewhere, in the wind, the faintest rattle of chains can still be heard.

Adventure Hooks for Future Sessions

- **The Mayor’s Secrets**: The Queen’s prison still exists—and the mayor’s uneasy gratitude suggests there is more he has not revealed.
- **Isla’s Fate**: Though the baby seems unharmed, does she carry some lingering connection to the Queen?

- **Jareth's Whereabouts**: The reluctant cultist fled into the night. If he still lives, will he seek redemption… or revenge?
- **The Fey Glade's Warning**: Those who gazed too deeply into the Pool of Echoes may continue to see visions—some of which may yet come to pass.
- **The Obelisk Remains Damaged**: Shadowbeasts still lurk in the hills, and strange occurrences continue.
- **Kalem's Favor Remains Unfulfilled**: If the party took a deal with Kalem, he will call it in soon.
- **The Queen Left a Mark on a Player**: A character has dreams of chains rattling, hinting she isn't fully gone.
- **The Cult Wasn't Entirely Destroyed**: A named NPC cultist escaped, perhaps now hunting the party.

For now, the party may rest. But shadows never sleep forever.